

Old Stone age

3.3.million years ago–11,500 years ago

Middle Stone Age

11,500–6,500 years ago

New Stone Age

6,500–4,000 years ago

After the Stone Age

4,000 years ago

Neolithic polished ax head



Microliths
(blade points)



New Stone Age (Neolithic)

“Neo” means “new,” and it describes a time when people moved away from hunting and gathering, and became farmers in many parts of the world. However, people still continued to use stone tools.

Bronze Age ax



Middle Stone Age (Mesolithic)

During this time, icy glaciers were melting and the seas were rising. People developed the tools they needed to deal with these changes. They became better at certain hunting skills, such as using harpoons (long spears) for catching fish.

After the Stone Age

Some societies started to make metal tools during periods called the Bronze Age and Iron Age. However, to this day there are still people in the world living as hunter-gatherers.

Sickle for
cutting grain



Iron Age
helmet



Neanderthals
had bigger
eyes and
brains than
humans.

Neanderthal

Neanderthals (*Homo neanderthalensis*) are our closest relatives. They lived between 250,000 and about 24,000 years ago. They had bigger brains than humans and it is not understood exactly why they died out.



Homo sapiens
had smaller
brains than
Neanderthals.

Homo sapiens

Humans that looked like we do today appeared in Africa about 200,000 years ago, but we are not sure how similar their brains were to ours today. About 12,000 years ago, they had spread to most of the world.